

“If the development is being done internally, the organisation will need to make sure that the manpower can be sustained. Then comes in the customisation costs. Many will want to customise the solution as per their needs, and that might cost extra in form of development cost,” shares Mahajan.

He adds, “Open source solution providers, such as Zimbra and Red Hat, usually offer open source solutions in subscription models. Red Hat charges 100% as a subscription cost. Keeping that in mind and calculating how much you will be paying in five years as subscription costs can also help organisations in assessing and choosing the right open source solution.

Deploying a new solution always requires the existing manpower to be trained on the same. This training not only costs money but also requires dedicating hours, and sometimes days or weeks, towards training and practicing. Additionally, both the internal and the external teams need to be trained in such a way that they are in sync with each other all the time.

“If you want to deploy Libreoffice instead of MS Office, you will encounter some features that are not usable. You will need to train the users on Libreoffice. It is not essential that open source adoption will lead to lowered costs, or open source cannot be deployed if the costs are higher.”

Freedom and flexibility

Freedom and flexibility are among the top reasons that have made open source what it is today. The freedom to choose solutions with the flexibility of customising existing solutions have not only empowered the community developing open source solutions but have also empowered the end users to choose and deploy.

Freedom and flexibility, in the simplest of terms, stands for access

to the source code. This access becomes essential for organisations such as the e-commerce portals coming up today because of the changes they are introducing on daily basis. However, this criterion does not hold the same value for all the organisations looking to deploy open source solutions.

“The freedom and flexibility assessment criteria is case-to-case. For instance, the way e-commerce portals are evolving on a day-to-day basis, they cannot work with solutions that are closed source. Such organisations are accessing open source solutions despite the higher costs,” explains Mahajan.

The second factor, flexibility, revolves around whether your internal team is flexible and capable enough to support these solutions, or will you be requiring external support (commercial) for the required support. Of course, the internal team, if there, will be required to upskill over time, and the management might also need to make extra efforts to sustain the team.

“You will have to decide whether you want self-support, or you will be needing commercial support. Either you should have the capability to support the solution internally, or you will have to reach out to the vendor, or any other third party for the same,” shares Mahajan.

He adds, “Adopting open source solutions requires being able to get suppliers in the long run. This matters a lot when we talk about

mature projects. If you are adopting any new solution and there are only a couple of suppliers supporting it, you might find it difficult to find suppliers, if the solution does not grow.”

Organisations which have dynamic requirements should carefully assess the freedom and flexibility factor. This is because they might require a lot of customisations, which in turn will require them to work with multiple suppliers at the same time. The frequent changes they need will always need the source code to be present at hand.

Matured solutions only

There are millions of open source solutions available in the market today. A lot of these also make repositories like GitHub on an everyday basis. However, it is not common for all of them to sustain themselves in the long term, in some cases even for short-term. Mahajan is of view that only about 5 to 10% of such solutions reach the mature stage.

What happens if you adopt a solution, and it is not able to mature with time? Choosing solutions that are mature over solutions that have just entered the market can make a big difference in the long-run as support will always be available for the former ones.

“If you are adopting any open source solution, you should always look at the maturity of the solution. Hence the project that you are deploying should be in the mature

